communal, you become vote-katua [cutter], you become B-team. So definitely I have progressed, thankfully. From 1998–2012, I was F-team of Congress Party. After leaving Congress Party, between 2012 and 2018, I have come up to B-team. So hopefully I will become A-team in another coming two–three years.'

Owaisi, who first became an MLA in 1994 from Hyderabad's Charminar, has a political career going back at least three decades. Yet, his national salience as a 'Muslim' politician has also risen in direct proportion to the BJP's ascendance and his assertive response to it. When he took oath for the fourth time as an MP in 2019, his walk to the podium was accompanied by some BJP MPs chanting slogans of 'Jai Sri Ram' and 'Vande Mataram'. He responded by first asking them to continue their chanting and then proceeding to read out his oath to the Indian Constitution in chaste Urdu, in the name of Khuda ('Khuda ke naam se'). He concluded with three slogans: 'Jai Bheem' (a nod to B.R. Ambedkar), 'Takbeer Allah-u-Akbar' (God is Great) and 'Jai Hind' (Hail India). It was another example of the complex interplay between the BJP's hardliners and Owaisi's own political positioning.

In Bihar, in 2020, Owaisi's party won five assembly seats in Seemanchal, which has over 30 per cent Muslim population, at the expense of the Congress and the RJD. Ironically, his impact also resulted in a Hindu counter-mobilisation: of thirty-two Muslim-significant seats, the BJP won twelve.[45] As a parliamentarian, Owaisi, who was once awarded the Sansad Ratna Award, has a record of asking questions on an eclectic range of policy issues. Of the 160 questions he raised in Parliament between July 2019 and November 2020, for example, only five pertained to minority issues.[46] Yet, in his political persona, he has emerged as the 'Muslim' counterpoint to the BJP's Hindutva narrative, focused on minority identity issues as much as the BJP is, in a sort of inverted mirror image.

The BJP's strategy of counter-polarisation in Muslim-significant areas was in evidence again in November 2020 when Yogi Adityanath, who was campaigning in the Greater Hyderabad Municipal Corporation (GHMC) elections, asked why Hyderabad—which has a 43.4 per cent Muslim population—could not be renamed